

INTR 4997: Sun Valley Internship Course 2.0

Anthony Campitelli

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Sun Valley YMCA Internship – Course Overview

Course Description

This internship partners The College of Idaho with the Wood River YMCA's Summer Bridge Program in Sun Valley, ID. Undergraduate students will assist with classroom learning (literacy, math, science) and facilitate structured enrichment activities for elementary students from largely low-SES, bilingual households while also learning from the broader educational, cultural, economic, and community context of Sun Valley. Drawing on the liberal arts tradition of the College of Idaho, the course asks students to connect experience with inquiry, creativity, communication, ethical reasoning, and civic responsibility.

A central feature of the course is a student-designed group project guided by the open-ended challenge: "Impress us." Working in groups, students will identify a topic, problem, question, or creative opportunity connected to their internship experience, the Sun Valley community, or their program of study. Projects may take many forms, including research, storytelling, community analysis, educational design, creative production, program improvement, or public-facing communication. Through this process, students will practice autonomy, collaboration, intellectual curiosity, and community engagement while producing work that is thoughtful, polished, and meaningful. This internship means many different things to many different people, and this format is designed to allow for exploration and critical thought within that framework in a way that enhances the experience for all involved.

Student Learning Outcomes

- Apply appropriate workplace behaviors in a youth-centered educational setting.
- Reflect critically on their role as mentors, learners, collaborators, and temporary members of the Sun Valley community.
- Connect their internship experience to broader liberal arts questions related to education, equity, community, culture, place, opportunity, and civic responsibility.
- Demonstrate autonomy and initiative by designing, developing, and presenting a self-selected group project.
- Collaborate effectively with peers to produce a polished project that reflects curiosity, effort, creativity, and meaningful engagement with the internship experience.
- Communicate the significance of their work to an audience of peers, faculty, supervisors, or community stakeholders.
- Evaluate their personal growth in independence, professionalism, leadership, and career readiness

Assignments

- **Weekly Timesheets:** Record of the hours worked during each week.
- **Group Project:** Student-designed group project connected to the Sun Valley experience, the Summer Bridge Program, community engagement, or students' academic/professional interests.
- **Final Presentation:** Public presentation of the group project and its connection to the internship experience, liberal arts learning, community engagement, and student growth.

Grading

- Fieldwork supervisor evaluation (40%)

- Group/final project (60%)

Rationale for Course Changes

The revised course structure places greater emphasis on student autonomy, experiential learning, community engagement, and liberal arts integration. The previous version of the course emphasized professional preparation, reflection, and career readiness, which remain important parts of the experience through participation in the Summer Bridge program. However, the new model adds a more open-ended, student-directed group project that asks students to move beyond completing assigned tasks and instead identify what is meaningful, interesting, useful, or intellectually compelling about their Sun Valley experience.

The central project prompt, "Impress us," is intentionally broad. It gives students room to approach the internship through the lens of their own interests, majors, talents, and future goals. Some groups may choose to investigate a community issue, while others may create a practical resource, design an educational activity, produce a public-facing story, analyze a social or economic question, or propose an improvement to the program. This structure reflects the goals of a liberal arts education by encouraging students to integrate knowledge across disciplines, ask better questions, communicate effectively, and produce work for an audience beyond the classroom.

The grading structure has been adjusted to recognize two major dimensions of the experience: performance in the field during the internship proper and the collaborative capstone project. This balance gives appropriate weight to the internship site while also recognizing the faculty instructor's role in guiding academic reflection, project development, and synthesis of the broader learning experience.

Sun Valley YMCA Internship – Assignment Instructions

Group Project

Task: Working in groups, design and complete a self-selected project connected to the Sun Valley internship experience, the Summer Bridge Program, the local community, or your academic/professional interests. The central instruction is simple: **impress us**.

Your project should demonstrate curiosity, effort, creativity, and meaningful engagement. It may be research-based, creative, practical, community-oriented, educational, analytical, expressive or some combination of these approaches. Strong projects will move beyond surface-level summary and show that your group noticed something important, asked a thoughtful question, produced a useful deliverable, created something sublime, or helped others see the internship experience in a new way.

Your group may produce a presentation, report, video, podcast, children's learning activity, community resource, proposal, website, map, toolkit, documentary-style story, data analysis, creative work, or another format approved by the instructor. The final project will be presented to the class, along with invited stakeholders, in the final week of the class. Weekly meetings will focus on a series of check-ins that will give an opportunity for dialectical engagement with the instructor and classmates in an effort to refine and enhance the projects along the way and to learn from each other as we go.

Project Expectations:

- The project must be completed collaboratively.
- The project must connect clearly to the Sun Valley experience, the Summer Bridge Program, community engagement, or your program of study.
- The project must result in a polished final product or presentation.
- The project must demonstrate thoughtful engagement rather than simply describing what happened.
- Each group member must contribute meaningfully to the final product.

Evaluation:

- Clear connection to internship, community, academic interests, or professional goals: 20%
- Creativity, originality, ambition, or practical value: 20%
- Depth of thought, analysis, reflection, or inquiry: 20%
- Quality and polish of final product: 20%
- Evidence of collaboration and shared contribution: 20%

Final Presentation

Task: During the final week of the experience, each group will deliver a polished presentation of its group project. Presentations should be approximately 8 to 12 minutes, depending on group size and project format. Groups may use PowerPoint, Canva, video, audio, handouts, demonstrations, websites, or other appropriate presentation tools.

The presentation should explain what the group created or investigated, why the project matters, and how it connects to the internship experience. Groups should also explain how the project reflects liberal arts learning, community engagement, experiential learning, and student autonomy.

Presentations should address the following:

- What your group chose to do
- Why you chose this project
- How it connects to Sun Valley, the Summer Bridge Program, community engagement, or your academic/professional interests
- What you learned through the process
- What makes the project thoughtful, useful, creative, or impressive
- How the experience shaped your understanding of yourself, your peers, the community, the internship experience, or your future work

Evaluation:

- Clear explanation of project purpose and significance: 20%
- Strong connection to internship experience, community engagement, or liberal arts learning: 20%
- Quality, creativity, and polish of the project: 20%
- Presentation organization, clarity, and delivery: 20%
- Evidence of group collaboration and thoughtful reflection: 10%
- Professionalism during presentation and Q&A: 10%

Sun Valley YMCA Internship – Group Project Guidelines

Project Description

Your project can be academic, creative, practical, community-based, research-oriented, or some combination of those things. It should connect to the Sun Valley experience, the Summer Bridge Program, your major, your future career, or a problem you think matters. The only real requirement is that your group produces something thoughtful, polished, and impressive enough that we are glad we gave you the freedom to choose it.

Project Topic Examples

1. The Economics of a Resort Town

- Explore how tourism, seasonal work, housing costs, the affordability of goods and services, and local businesses shape economic, personal, and family life in the Sun Valley region.

2. Who Gets to Live in Sun Valley?

- Investigate housing affordability, workforce housing, commuting patterns, or cost of living and comment on how these factors affect demographics in Sun Valley.

3. Tourism and Community Identity

- Examine how Sun Valley balances being a destination for tourists and other part-time residents with being a home for year-round residents and constructs an identity from that unique social milieu.

4. Seasonal Employment and the Local Workforce

- Study the types of jobs created by tourism and how seasonal labor affects workers and businesses.

5. Outdoor Recreation and Environmental Stewardship

- Analyze how hiking, skiing, biking, fishing, or other outdoor activities affect land use and conservation. Present mechanisms that are, or should be, utilized in Sun Valley to pursue environmental stewardship.

6. The History of Sun Valley

- Create a project on Sun Valley's development as a ski resort, its cultural history, or its role in Idaho's identity.

7. Sun Valley Beyond the Tourist Brochure

- Compare how Sun Valley is marketed to tourists and seasonal residents with the lived experiences of year-round residents, workers, and students.

8. Transportation in a Mountain Community

- Explore how people get around Sun Valley and nearby towns, including public transit, commuting, biking, and walkability. Examine how zoning restrictions, local ordinances, and urban planning in the region impact transportation.

9. Food Systems in a Resort Community

- Look at restaurants, local agriculture, food access, grocery prices, or the relationship between tourism and food culture.

10. Education and Opportunity in Rural Idaho

- Examine the broader public education system and how programs like the summer bridge internship support elementary students and address educational gaps.

11. What Helps Elementary Students Catch Up Academically?

- Review strategies used in summer bridge programs and evaluate how these comport with educational best practices and what seems most helpful.

12. Designing a Better Summer Learning Experience

- Propose improvements to the Wood River summer bridge program based on student engagement, learning, belonging, or motivation.

13. Learning Through Play

- Develop a project on how games, movement, art, or storytelling can support elementary learning.

14. Mentorship and Role Modeling

- Explore how college students serving as mentors might influence younger students' academic confidence.

15. Building Confidence in Struggling Learners

- Create a project around academic self-efficacy, growth mindset, or student identity. Present mechanisms that could be leveraged to develop these key, and often intangible, soft skills in young learners.

16. Culturally Responsive Summer Programming

- Explore how summer programs can better connect with students' families, communities, languages, and lived experiences.

17. What Makes a Child Feel Like They Belong in School?

- Interview, observe, or synthesize research on belonging, inclusion, and classroom climate.

18. Why Some Students Stop Trying

- Examine learned helplessness, frustration, confidence, or repeated academic struggle. Compare the lived experiences of students in the summer bridge program to what is known about how these factors impact the educational experience and outcomes.

19. Peer Relationships in Summer Programs

- Study how friendships, group belonging, and peer support affect engagement and performance from a cultural, social, and psychological perspective.

20. Stress, Poverty, and Academic Performance

- Explore how life outside school can affect learning and behavior in the classroom from an economic, sociological, and psychological vantage.

21. Helping Students See Themselves as "Smart"

- Create a project focused on academic identity, confidence, and student voice. How can we facilitate higher academic confidence and self-efficacy in young learners, and what are the consequences of not doing so?

22. Movement as a Learning Tool

- Design activities that combine physical activity with reading, math, or science learning that could function as a meaningful learning experience for children in the Summer Bridge program.

23. Physical Activity and Attention in Children

- Explore whether movement breaks, games, or outdoor play help elementary students focus through a review of the literature synthesized with student and teacher perspectives.

24. The Role of Recess and Play in Learning

- Investigate how unstructured play supports social, emotional, and cognitive development, both in terms of educational performance and cognitive development.

25. Nutrition and Learning

- Examine how breakfast, snacks, hydration, or food insecurity might affect student attention and performance and analyze how well the Summer Bridge host school is meeting those needs.

26. Sleep and School Readiness

- Create an educational project about how sleep influences learning, behavior, and mood in children utilizing surveys and interviews to present a quantitative and qualitative snapshot.

27. Designing an Active Summer Camp Day

- Build a sample daily schedule that balances academic support, physical activity, rest, and fun using feedback from Summer Bridge educators, stakeholders and students.

28. Screen Time, Outdoor Time, and Child Development

- Explore how children's daily environments influence attention, health, and learning drawing a comparison between time spent looking at screens and time spent pursuing outdoor activities.

29. Marketing the Summer Bridge Program

- Create a marketing campaign to communicate the value of the program to parents, donors, schools, or community partners.

30. Telling the Story of the Internship

- Produce a short video, photo essay, podcast, or written feature about the student and intern experience.

31. Community Partner Map

- Identify organizations in the Sun Valley area that could support education, recreation, health, or youth development and draft a plan for integrating those organizations in ways that enhance the Summer Bridge program.

32. Measuring Program Impact

- Propose simple ways to evaluate whether the internship helped elementary students, college interns, or the community beyond simply evaluating test scores and other standard educational outcomes.

33. A Children's Book Inspired by Sun Valley

- Write and illustrate a story that teaches a lesson related to confidence, nature, school, or community.

34. A Mini Documentary

- Create a short film about the program, the community, or the educational challenges the program addresses.

35. A Podcast Episode

- Produce an episode interviewing interns, teachers, families, or community members.

36. A Field Guide for Future Interns

- Create a practical guide with advice, lesson ideas, local context, and things interns wish they had known.

37. A Public Presentation for Community Stakeholders

- Prepare a polished presentation that could be shared with donors, school leaders, or community partners to build connections with the program.

38. A Game That Teaches Academic Skills

- Design a math, reading, science, or movement-based game for elementary students that would enhance the learning objectives of the program.

39. A Toolkit for Elementary Student Engagement

- Build a collection of activities, scripts, movement breaks, reflection prompts, or classroom management tools that can help teachers or students navigate the challenges of the program and set them up for success.

40. Summer Bridge: A Performance

- Design and perform an artistic piece (play, interpretive dance, etc.) that illustrates an important element of the Sun Valley experience.

41. A “Day in the Life” Comparison

- Compare the daily experience of a visitor, a local worker, a local student, and a college intern in Sun Valley.

42. An Interactive Map of Learning in Sun Valley

- Map places where children can learn outside the classroom: parks, libraries, trails, museums, community spaces.

43. A Proposal for Next Year’s Internship

- Redesign part of the internship to make it more effective, meaningful, sustainable, or impressive.

44. An Artistic Interpretation of Sun Valley

- Create a fine arts piece or collection of pieces (painting, sculpture, etc.) that capture the internship experience or an aspect of the region, culture, or society.